

IndabaX Egypt 2026 - Program Master Plan

Internal working document. Drives invitations and the run of show. The public site stays high-level until speakers confirm.

Status legend: CONFIRMED = said yes. INVITED = invitation out, awaiting reply. OPEN = slot needs a person; target profile written in the scope.

Slot rules: first signed takes the slot; a late marquee acceptance goes to the 16:15 plenary of the same day ("printed program closed" line). No session runs without a named backup by 5 August.

Stage hierarchy rule: the main stage belongs to the people the conference stands on (confirmed core speakers, marquee guests) plus the published Gold/Platinum 30-minute slots. Halls host labs, parallel open sessions and student talks. Workshop talk-parts happen on the main stage; only the hands-on part moves to Hall A.

Day 1 - Sunday 16 August 2026 (09:00 - 18:00) - Theme: From using AI to building it

Main stage (Plenary)

Time	Session	Speaker / Status	Exact scope: what is covered
08:30-09:00	Registration and networking	Team	Badge pickup, welcome coffee, sponsor booths open. Volunteers guide people to halls.
09:00-09:20	Opening ceremony and community welcome	INVITED: Prof. Aboul Ella Hassanien (D1 or D2, his choice)	Official welcome, what the Indaba movement is, why Egypt has a national edition, his vision for the Egyptian research generation. If Prof. Hassanien prefers Day 2 or closing, the committee chair opens.
09:20-10:00	Opening keynote: Raising trusted AI	INVITED: Mo Gawdat (in person or remote). Fallback: strongest confirmed keynote	40 minutes. The trust question in GenAI: hallucination, alignment, and who teaches the machines. Framed for young builders: what to build and what to refuse to build. 10 minutes moderated questions included.
10:00-10:20	Coffee break	-	Sponsor booths and posters preview.
10:20-11:00	Main-stage talk: why models die in production (W2 part 1)	CONFIRMED: Dr. Hazem Ali (Founder and CEO, Skytells; Microsoft AI MVP)	40 minutes to the full hall: drift, silent failures, retraining debt, monitoring blind spots, real cases from two decades of enterprise AI. Ends with an open call: whoever wants to build this for real, Hall A at 11:10. The hands-on continues there as W2 part 2.
11:00-11:45	Main-stage session: building iSchool from Egypt to MENA scale	INVITED: Muhammad Gawish (Co-founder and CEO, iSchool)	35 minutes plus 10 of questions. The story told operationally: first product, first hires, the economics of education, 131,000 learners, and what he would not do again.
11:45-12:25	Main-stage talk: vision systems at national scale	INVITED: Asmaa Ahmed E. Osman (Staff AI Vision Scientist, Fawry; Lecturer, FCAI-CU)	Document and identity verification at Egypt's largest fintech: where models fail on real documents, and the bridge from lecture hall to production line.
15:00-15:30	Industry talk I (reserved sponsor slot)	OPEN: Gold/Platinum sponsor	30 minutes. Sponsor presents a real technical case study, not a company ad: a system they built, the failure they fixed, the stack they used. Committee reviews slides beforehand.
15:30-16:00	Industry talk II (reserved sponsor slot)	OPEN: Gold/Platinum sponsor	Same format as Industry talk I.
16:15-17:00	Overflow keynote / plenary talk slot	RESERVED for late marquee acceptance (e.g., Dr. Awadallah) else becomes extended networking	Held empty on purpose per slot rules. Announce internally only.
17:00-17:30	Day 1 wrap-up	Team	Recap, next-day preview, logistics.

Hall A - Workshops (hands-on room). Rule: talk parts happen on the main stage; Hall A is for building only

W2 part 2 (11:10-12:30): production ML lab, continuation of Dr. Hazem's main-stage talk

Lead: CONFIRMED: Dr. Hazem Ali. The talk (part 1) is on the main stage at 10:20; this is the build.

Format split: 80 minutes fully hands-on for the subset that follows him from the plenary.

Content, in order: Take a trained model from a notebook to a served endpoint: package it, containerize it, deploy, then attach basic monitoring and an alert.

What attendees leave with: A model of their own deployed behind an endpoint with a live monitoring dashboard.

Prerequisites: Laptop, basic Python, Docker installed or Colab fallback provided.

W1 (13:30-15:45, two blocks with a 15-min break): Build your first RAG system, in Arabic

Lead: OPEN - target: GenAI practitioner who ships retrieval systems (candidates: Hazem Ali referral network, Microsoft MVPs, Omar Maher team)

Format split: 20 minutes concepts, then 100 minutes guided build. Not a lecture: screens on from minute 21.

Content, in order: (1) 20 min: how retrieval-augmented generation actually works: embeddings, chunking, vector search, grounding, evaluation. (2) 40 min: build the index: load an Arabic document set, chunk it, embed it, store it. (3) 40 min: wire the LLM: retrieval prompt, citation of sources, guardrails against hallucination. (4) 20 min: break it on purpose: adversarial questions, measure faithfulness, fix chunking.

What attendees leave with: A working RAG chatbot over Arabic documents running in their own Colab, plus an evaluation notebook.

Prerequisites: Laptop, Google account (Colab), basic Python. No local installs needed.

Halls B / C / D - Track talks (parallel, 10:20-12:30 and 13:30-15:45)

Time	Session	Speaker / Status	Exact scope: what is covered
10:20-11:20	Hall B: AI for Healthcare - opening talk	OPEN - target: clinical-AI practitioner (Rology network, Nermin Negied)	What it takes to put a model in front of a doctor: data scarcity, regulatory reality in Egypt, clinical validation vs benchmark accuracy. One real deployment walked end to end.
10:20-11:20	Hall C: Arabic NLP and speech - opening talk	INVITED: track headliner TBD after Prof. Diab confirms her slot	State of Arabic NLP 2026: what works (dialect LLMs, speech), what does not (evaluation, data), where a student can contribute in 12 months.
10:20-11:20	Hall D: Startups and applied AI - opening talk	OPEN - target: founder or applied-AI lead (Flat6Labs/Falak network, Rology)	Taking an AI product to its first 100 customers in Egypt: pricing, data realities, first hires. Main-stage core sessions run in parallel; this hall serves the startup-focused subset.
11:30-12:30	Hall B: research talks: academic AI	OPEN - 3 slots of 20 min from accepted abstracts	Three short research talks selected by the poster committee from strongest submissions.
11:30-12:30	Hall C: LLMs, RAG and data systems	OPEN - target: data/platform engineer from industry	How production teams actually feed LLMs: pipelines, quality, cost control, caching. Complements W1.
11:30-12:30	Hall D: AI for Finance and Industry	OPEN - target: fintech/industry ML practitioner (Valify, e-finance, banks network)	Applied ML in Egyptian finance and industry beyond vision: fraud, credit, forecasting. The headline Finance and Industry talk (Fawry) is on the main stage at 11:45.
13:30-14:30	Hall B: health data in practice	OPEN	Working with hospital data: privacy under Egyptian law (PDPL), imbalance, annotation with clinicians.
13:30-14:30	Hall C: responsible AI, evaluation and safety	OPEN - target: researcher in evaluation/safety (Diab network, DLI network)	Concrete evaluation of LLMs beyond vibes: harness design, Arabic-specific failure modes, red-teaming basics.
13:30-14:30	Hall D: industry case studies	OPEN: sponsor slots (Silver+)	Two 25-minute technical case studies from sponsors, same no-ad rule as main-stage industry talks.
14:45-15:45	Hall B: short papers and student talks	OPEN - from abstracts	Four 12-minute student presentations, chaired by poster committee.
14:45-15:45	Hall C: open science and learning pathways	OPEN - target: community organizer (GDG/AWS UG confirmed contacts fit here)	How to grow in AI from Egypt with free resources: study plans that work, communities, competitions, first contributions.
14:45-15:45	Hall D: AI education and	INVITED: Abdelrahman (Education Partner)	Panel-style hour: how Egypt builds its next AI generation, K-12 to university. Includes the Education Partner segment: students demo real

	talent pipeline	student showcase component here if he prefers Day 1	built projects on stage (10-15 min).
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Day 2 - Monday 17 August 2026 (09:00 - 18:00) - Theme: Research to production

Main stage (Plenary)

Time	Session	Speaker / Status	Exact scope: what is covered
09:00-09:20	Day 2 welcome	Team (or Prof. Hassanien if he chose Day 2)	Short recap, poster session instructions, day map.
09:20-10:00	Day 2 keynote: Multimodal and creative AI	INVITED: Prof. Mohamed Elhoseiny (KAUST), in person preferred, remote welcome	40 minutes. From vision-language research to open models the room already uses: how a lab builds work the world adopts, and the frontier of creative and multimodal AI. Positioned right before the GenAI workshops so attendees walk out and build.
12:00-12:40	Arabic NLP track keynote (plenary, timezone-planned)	INVITED: Prof. Mona Diab (CMU LTI) - Cairo noon = Pittsburgh early morning; if she prefers later, 16:15 slot = 9:15 am Pittsburgh	40 minutes, remote-first production (tested link, moderator in the hall, big screen). The future of Arabic language technologies: where the field must go, and what Egyptian students should work on next.
15:00-15:30	Industry talk III (reserved sponsor slot)	OPEN: Gold/Platinum sponsor	Same technical-case-study format as Day 1.
15:30-16:00	Industry talk IV (reserved sponsor slot)	OPEN: Gold/Platinum sponsor	Same format.
16:15-17:00	Closing panel: Egypt's AI ecosystem, from research to products	INVITED anchor: Prof. Haitham Hamza (Dean, FCAI-CU; Chairman, SECC-ITIDA) + 3 seats: one founder (Gawish or Maher), one sponsor CTO, one researcher	45 minutes moderated. The pipeline question: faculty output, industry absorption, national programs. Ends with one commitment from each panelist: what they will do for this pipeline before IndabaX 2027.
17:00-17:30	Day 2 wrap-up	Team	Recap, awards-day instructions.

Hall A - Workshops

W3 (10:20-12:30): Agentic AI: build an agent that actually does something

Lead: OPEN - target: practitioner shipping agents/tool-use (MVP network, Monta AI team if Maher engages)

Format split: 15 minutes concepts, 105 minutes guided build. Screens on from minute 16.

Content, in order: (1) 15 min: what an agent is beyond the hype: tools, planning loops, guardrails, when NOT to build an agent. (2) 45 min: build a tool-using agent over a real API (weather/finance/docs) with function calling. (3) 30 min: add memory and error recovery. (4) 15 min: evaluate it: task success rate, not vibes.

What attendees leave with: A working tool-using agent in their own environment plus an agent-evaluation checklist.

Prerequisites: Laptop, Colab, basic Python. W1 attendance helps but is not required.

W4 (13:30-15:00): Education Partner session (if Abdelrahman chooses Day 2) OR second run of W1 by popular demand

Lead: INVITED: Education Partner (60 min: 30 company/vision + 30 student demos) OR W1 lead repeats

Format split: If Education Partner: 30 min talk + 30 min student demos + 30 min mentoring circle with attendees.

Content, in order: Education path: how kids 10-16 learn to build real products; live demos by his students of projects they built; open mentoring circle: attendees who teach or plan to teach ask anything.

What attendees leave with: A written mini-guide: how to run a kids coding program that produces builders, not tool users.

Prerequisites: None.

15:15-16:45: Evaluation clinic (small groups)

Lead: OPEN - target: senior practitioners comfortable reviewing strangers' work live, 4 facilitators

Format split: Fully hands-on. No slides at all. Four working tables of up to 8, one facilitator each.

Content, in order: Attendees bring their own model, notebook, or project. Each table runs a 20-minute cycle per project: define the metric that actually matters, build a minimal eval harness, find where the model is lying, write the next experiment. Facilitators rotate.

What attendees leave with: Their own project evaluated properly, with a written next-steps card.

Prerequisites: Bring your own project (announced at registration). Walk-ins pair up as reviewers.

Poster session (Shared area, 13:30-15:00)

Accepted abstracts presented as A0 posters. Committee walk at 13:45. Invited-guest walk at 14:15: Prof. Elhoseiny has agreed-in-principle to walk the posters and give feedback if he confirms; pair him with two committee members. Best-poster shortlist decided 14:45, announced at Day 3 awards.

Halls B / C / D - Track talks

Time	Session	Speaker / Status	Exact scope: what is covered
10:20-11:20	Hall B: AI for Healthcare - imaging and diagnostics	OPEN	Deep dive on one modality (radiology or pathology): dataset, model, clinical workflow integration, what changed for the physician.
10:20-11:20	Hall C: Arabic speech technologies	OPEN - target: speech practitioner (RDI alumni network, Hamza referral)	ASR and TTS for Egyptian Arabic in production: data collection, dialect handling, latency budgets.
10:20-11:20	Hall D: founders clinic	OPEN - target: 2 founders + 1 investor (Flat6Labs/Falak contacts)	Office-hours format: startups in the room get 15 minutes each of blunt feedback on their AI product from founders who shipped.
11:30-12:30	Hall B/C/D	-	Halls pause; everyone to plenary for the Arabic NLP keynote at 12:00.

Day 3 - Tuesday 18 August 2026 (09:00 - 17:00) - Theme: Community, celebration, next generation

Time	Session	Speaker / Status	Exact scope: what is covered
09:00-09:30	Arrival and coffee	-	Relaxed start, music, photo wall open.
09:30-10:05	Community keynote (main stage)	INVITED: Osama Elzero	35 minutes, his format: from self-taught, Arabic-speaking developer to world-class builder, and now to AI engineer: the honest path, the discipline, and what the next five years demand from this generation. No slides required, fireside chairs on stage, moderated by a committee member.
10:05-10:45	The Da7ee7 segment (main stage)	INVITED: Ahmed El Ghandour (Da7ee7)	35 to 40 minutes in his style: how AI actually works, told the way only he tells it, in front of the generation building it. Ends on stage with the youngest builders of the event standing beside him.
10:45-11:30	Awards ceremony, group photo and closing	Team + guests (run of show below)	(1) Best poster awards, 3 winners, handed by the senior academic guest present. (2) Education Partner student awards: youngest builders receive certificates. (3) iSchool scholarships (if confirmed) handed by Da7ee7 to winning students: the photo of the event. (4) Official group photo, full hall. (5) Closing words, 5 minutes, thanks and IndabaX 2027 tease.
11:30-17:00	Entertainment and community afternoon	Team	Games, activities, community celebration, informal networking. Lunch included. Optional attendance (asked at registration).

Awards hour is crowded by design: it stacks every partner moment into the most photographed 45 minutes of the event. A minute-level run of show will be written once Da7ee7, iSchool and the Education Partner confirm. Hard rule: no partner speech longer than 90 seconds during awards.

Open slots: the recruiting checklist

Time	Session	Speaker / Status	Exact scope: what is covered
D1 10:20	W1 lead: RAG hands-on	OPEN	GenAI practitioner who ships. Ask Hazem for one referral (his exact network). 20/100 split as specced.
D2 15:15	Evaluation clinic facilitators x4	OPEN	Senior practitioners; low prep; great slot for wave-2 locals.
D1 10:20	Hall D startups opening talk	OPEN	Founder or applied-AI lead; Flat6Labs/Falak/Rology network.
D2 10:20	W3 lead: Agentic AI	OPEN	Same profile as W1; can be same person if strong.
D1/D2	Hall B healthcare talks x3	OPEN	Clinical-AI practitioners; Rology thread + Asmaa referrals (FCAI network).
D1/D2	Hall C speech + responsible AI	OPEN	Speech: RDI alumni. Responsible AI: Diab network or DLI network.
D1/D2	Industry talks x4 + case studies x2	OPEN	Sold with Gold/Platinum. Technical case-study rule enforced.
D2 16:15	Panel seats x3 beside Prof. Hamza	OPEN	One founder (Gawish/Maher), one sponsor CTO, one researcher.

Every invitation from today names the exact slot, time, scope and split from this document. Nothing generic goes out.